Wadia Hospitals

The Doctor Who Chose the Children No One Else Would

Dr. Minnie Bodhanwala did not build a career in healthcare. She built an institution—and in doing so, set the standard for what charitable paediatric care in India is capable of becoming.



Dr. Minnie Bodhanwala
CEO of Nowrosjee Wadia Maternity Hospital & Bai Jerbai Wadia Hospital for Children

There is a child in the memory of every doctor who has worked at Bai Jerbai Wadia Hospital for Children. A child who arrived with nothing — no money, no referral letter from a private specialist, no family with institutional connections — and left with something that no private hospital could have given them at that price: their life, intact, and their dignity, uncompromised.

It is for such a child that Dr. Minnie Bodhanwala has spent three decades building one of India's most consequential healthcare institutions. And the scale of what she has built — quietly, persistently, against every institutional constraint that underfunded charitable healthcare in India imposes — is a record that the country's health policy community is only beginning to fully comprehend.

The Bai Jerbai Wadia Hospital for Children is India's first and largest dedicated paediatric hospital. The Nowrosjee Wadia Maternity Hospital completes the continuum: from birth to childhood, the Wadia complex in Mumbai handles over four lakh outpatients and 30,000 inpatients every year. Under Dr. Bodhanwala's leadership as CEO, the institutions have received 40-plus national and international accreditations—a quality infrastructure that places Wadia in the same conversation as the finest paediatric centres in the world, at a fraction of the access barrier.

The milestones she has set are not incremental. Asia's largest NICU, at 155 beds. A Human Milk Bank that ensures the most vulnerable newborns receive the safest possible nutrition. A UNICEF Maharashtra State Centre of Excellence on malnutrition — built on the recognition that a child's health outcomes are inseparable from the nutritional environment of the first thousand days of life. Fifty-plus personal healthcare leadership awards. And a biography, Defying Conventions, whose title is the most concise summary of her career available.

"The measure of any healthcare system," Dr. Bodhanwala has said, "is not the care it gives to those who can pay for it—it is the care it gives to those who cannot."

That measure, applied consistently across thirty years, is what has made Wadia Hospitals not merely a medical institution but a national public health asset. The children it serves are predominantly from families for whom Wadia is the only option—and the quality they receive is not the quality of the only option. It is world-class care, delivered without condition.

"Excellence is not a luxury that charitable hospitals cannot afford," she has observed. "It is the only thing they cannot afford to be without."

Dr. Bodhanwala also serves as Board Director of Bombay Dyeing, National Peroxide, and the Bombay Burmah Trading Corporation—a corporate governance role that reflects the institutional stature she has earned in India's broader leadership community. But it is in the wards of Wadia, where a child who arrived with nothing leaves with everything that matters, that her legacy is most completely written.